BOOKS

HIS X-RAY VISION

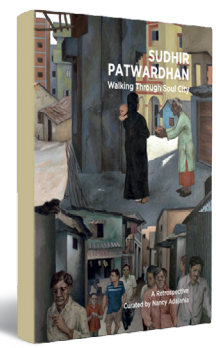
*A new book shows why **Sudhir Patwardhan** is, in all likelihood, India's greatest living painter*



In her introduction to *Sudhir Patwardhan: Walking Through Soul City*, the mammoth volume that follows an excellent retrospective at the National Gallery of Modern Art in Mumbai from November 2019 to February 2020, the curator Nancy Adajania writes, "I would advance the claim that, after M.F. Husain, it is Patwardhan who commands the widespread attention of Indian viewers across several generations."

It is an apt comparison, and not just for that one reason. Both these artists, born roughly three decades apart in the turbulent first half of the 20th century, have portrayed—and indeed embodied—the story of modern India in ambitious narrative paintings that only look more interesting with each passing year. This is especially true in the case of Patwardhan, whose masterworks from the early 1980s onwards possessed a veritably canonical heft, but now, from our 21st century vantage, we can clearly see that his pulsating, indispensable oeuvre is amongst the best of our best, and, perhaps, the greatest of all.

Adajania does justice to this consistently stunning corpus in her literally monumental book (it is almost 500 pages long and weighs nearly 4 kilos). Explaining her approach, she writes, "In bringing together the various phases of Patwardhan's practice, this retrospective plays linear chronology against the artist's deep, recurrent preoccupations: his insistence on crafting place from layers of memory, his engagement with the subaltern figure in its vulnerability and strength, his curiosity about what brings people together into various forms of collective formations and what tears them apart."



Sudhir Patwardhan: Walking Through Soul City
by Nancy Adajania (Editor)
THE GUILD
₹6,000; 496 pages

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THE MASTER'S TOUCH
Below, *Nullah*, 1985; and bottom, *Mumbai Proverbs*, 2014





Here, it is essential to understand the twinned frames of reference that bookend Patwardhan's perspective and his artistic practice. In his mien and search for meaning, he is a thoroughbred 1970s Indian Leftist in the George Fernandes mould and was resolute in his opposition to the Emergency. He also graduated from the Armed Forces Medical College and started working as a radiologist in Thane in 1975—his "day job" for the next three decades (from 2005, he has been a full-time artist).

The critic and curator Ranjit Hoskote—who is married to Nancy Adajania—puts it beautifully in his own excellent 2004 book, *Sudhir Patwardhan: The Complicit Observer*: "Patwardhan the painter operated with the same penetrating vision as Patwardhan the